

sword of revolution is sharpened on the whetting-stone of ideas.”

■ By Anjum Rajabali

The question that bothered me the most when I began my research to write the script for *The Legend of Bhagat Singh* was the most obvious one. Why did he want to die?

He was a young healthy man of 23, with a sunny personality, was loved by all who knew him, intelligent and witty with a great fondness for all that life had to offer from literature to rasagullas, and everything in between. He lived every moment to the fullest. An-hour-and-a-half before he was to be hanged, he was eagerly devouring Lenin's latest biography. So, why then was he so keen on dying?

For this, it was important to meet the man behind the legend, to trace his emotional arc. I decided to journey his life with him as an observer. Born into a politically active family, even as a child he knew that India was under foreign rule. But the gruesome implications of this fact kicked in only after the Jallianwala Bagh massacre.

Overcome with grief, he ran away from school to Amritsar to visit the site. So moved was he that he gathered up some blood-soaked mud into a little bottle. This reminder of the horrendous cruelty that is inevitable when people's freedom is taken away would remain with him all his life. And it was then, while staring at those bullet-ridden walls, that this boy of 11 knew what he wanted more than anything else in the world. He wanted his country to be free.

And Gandhi was showing the way. When he called for non-cooperation, Bhagat became his energetic soldier. But unable to comprehend the maturity of Gandhi's decision to abort the campaign after the Chauri-Chaura violence, young Bhagat felt acutely let down. He had to now seek his own answer—how does one fight for freedom? He found his answer in Marxism, revolutionary struggle. But the enquiry took him beyond mere freedom—towards nation-building. At the age of 16, Bhagat's ideal grew and strengthened into a mature vision for

a new India—based on the principles of socialism and secularism. That is what he would strive for now.

When Lala Lajpat Rai died due to blows inflicted by British policemen's lathi charge, Bhagat had a militant reaction. The oppressor's violence had to be met with revolutionary counter-violence. With his comrades, he pumped four bullets into the offending officer. It turned out to be a turning point of his life, impelling him to question his own strategy. Two years of honest introspection led to the resolution that violence was not the answer to oppression. Building a people's movement to struggle for a new society was. But as a fugitive himself how was he to reach the people?

A spectacular idea struck him: Throw a bomb in the National Assembly! Assuming that this was to massacre politicians, Chandra-shekhar Azad was delighted. But Bhagat didn't want to hurt anyone. "It takes a loud noise to make the deaf hear," he said. Once arrested, he

would use the court room as a platform to speak to the people. Using his words, his comrades would create a people's movement. It was a remarkably sophisticated strategy. The decision to kill the police officer had been a *reaction* to British oppression, throwing the bomb was a mature *response* to it.

The catch of course was that the government would hang him for the British officer's murder. But that didn't matter to him. All that mattered was his ideal—a genuinely free India. And for that, his life—or death—was merely an instrument. At 23, Bhagat Singh had become a complete idealist. His cause was above his own life. I tried to imagine what it must be to feel like this. To want to die—not for a loved one, but for a cause, for an ideal, with joy and *josh*. Frankly, I don't really know still. And my tepid script reflected that.

But within weeks of his arrest, all his comrades were caught, destroying any chance of a people's movement. But Bhagat was now firmly on the heroic path. And heroes never give up on their cause. With courageous and powerful speeches in the court, he made his voice heard and articulated his vision for a free India. When he undertook a fast for 63 days to protest against discrimination in jail, he was hammered daily. He never hit back. Violence was no longer an option, no matter what the provocation was. In his growth, I began seeing shades of Vivekananda and Buddha. And ironically, also of his great political adversary, Mahatma Gandhi.

Today, everyone wants a piece of Bhagat Singh. Even the Sangh Parivar, whose politics he was dead against. People vote for him as the greatest Indian. His reference is used to accord substance and legitimacy to confused heroes in popular films. But to appreciate him is to understand the true essence of his heroism. It didn't lie in his use of the gun once but in the aggressive harmony of his beliefs and his actions.

The author is one of the country's foremost scriptwriters



Q: Which organisation was Bhagat Singh a part of?

A: Hindustan Socialist Republican Association

Q: Why did he run away from home?

A: To avoid an early marriage

Q: Which book appealed him the most in his search on atheism?

A: Niralamba Swami's *Common Sense*

Q: Who was his inspiration?

A: Kartar Singh Sarabha, a revolutionary involved in the Lahore conspiracy case

Q: Who was Bhagat Singh's favourite poet?

A: Allama Iqbal from Sialkot